Shah to suggest that this was more than just a ‘wave’ election—it was something bigger, much bigger.

Tsunami in India is associated with the terrible disaster that hit the southern coast of the country in December 2004, spreading death and destruction. This election did not result in deaths, but it did destroy certain rigidly held beliefs about politics in this country. It was the death in a way of long-held orthodoxies about voting patterns. The death of a conventional rural–urban divide, of traditional caste and regional loyalties, of family ties, of paternalistic governance, maybe even of the Nehruvian consensus that had dominated Indian politics for decades. To quote Guha from a column written a day after the verdict: ‘The sometimes noble, sometimes ignoble, “structure of renown” erected by Motilal Nehru and his descendants is now merely a heap of rubble.’ Stereotypes of which social groups voted for the Congress, which for the Bharatiya Janata Party and which for caste-based parties have been demolished. The political earth of India shook, moving the centre of gravity of an Indian election from identity politics to aspirational politics. It’s a new ‘plus’ factor that now gets you the crucial additional support, beyond narrow appeals to caste and community vote banks.

Election 2014 saw a shift in outcomes, processes and personalities. The outcome itself was staggering. The BJP became the first non-Congress party to win a clear majority on its own (the Janata Party in 1977 was a collection of several parties). In its original avatar as the Jana Sangh, the party had won just three seats and 3.1 per cent of the vote in the 1952 election. Now, it has won 282 seats and 31 per cent of the national vote—astonishing figures when you consider that the BJP’s catchment area of winnable seats was less than 350 seats. The lotus has truly bloomed and come a very long way from the time when it was pigeonholed as a Brahmin–Bania party.

In six states, the BJP won each and every seat on offer. Its strike rate across north and west India was over 80 per cent, with the party winning more than four of every five seats it contested in this belt. It is in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar—two states that we believed were locked into an enduring caste matrix—that the BJP achieved some of its more dramatic